1 | Introduction

India's and Pakistan's nuclear tests of May 1998 put to rest years of speculation as to whether the two countries, long suspected of developing covert weapons capabilities, would openly exercise their so-called nuclear option. The dust had hardly settled from the tests, however, when a firestorm of debate erupted over nuclear weapons' regional security implications. Optimistic observers argued that nuclearization would stabilize South Asia by making Indo-Pakistani conflict prohibitively risky. Pessimistic observers maintained that, given India and Pakistan's bitter historical rivalry, as well as the possibility of accident and miscalculation, proliferation would make the subcontinent more dangerous.[1] The tenth anniversary of the tests offered scholars an opportunity to revisit this issue with the benefit of a decade of hindsight. What lessons did the intervening years hold regarding nuclear weapons' impact on South Asian security?

Answering this question is important not simply from an academic standpoint; it has significant real-world implications. South Asia has emerged as a major player in international affairs, thanks in large part to its rapidly growing economy. India, which had been plagued by chronic underdevelopment for most of its history, has in recent years enjoyed GDP growth of approximately 8 percent. The country has become an important force in the information technology sector, a major source of skilled labor, and a burgeoning market for foreign exports.[2] In addition, South Asia's population is enormous. With well over 1 billion people between them, India and Pakistan account for more than one-fifth of the human race.[3] The subcontinent's conventional military power is also growing, with Indian capabilities in particular increasing rapidly.[4] Finally, South Asia has emerged as a